

The Lyric Engine

A Systematic Method for AI-Assisted Song Construction from Dense Source Material

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I. ABSTRACT

This paper documents a systematic method for transforming dense technical, philosophical, or investigative source material into maximally information-dense songs using LLM collaboration, targeting Suno as the production platform. The method was developed through the production of two albums — Obvious and A Rational World — comprising 24 songs built from a corpus of cross-domain research papers spanning physics, mathematics, neuroscience, epistemology, and institutional analysis. The method was subsequently validated through a third album — Culture — comprising 9 songs built from the CULT paper series on institutional analysis.

The method produces songs that operate on two simultaneous layers: a surface layer that functions as a complete song for any listener with zero source context, and a depth layer that compresses the source material’s structural payload for informed listeners. Neither layer degrades the other. The method is documented from practice, validated against produced work, and reproducible by any practitioner with source material, an LLM, and access to Suno.

Forty rules govern the construction. The original twenty-eight were derived from the first two albums. Six additional rules were derived from an independent external application by a different LLM instance. Six more were derived from the Culture album production. Each rule was derived from a specific failure observed during production — a line that didn’t sing, a metaphor that broke, a word that flattened, a pattern that repeated across songs until it became invisible. The rules are the scar tissue of three albums. They prevent the failures that produced them.

The rule set is open. Every production cycle will generate new failures the current rules don’t catch. Each failure becomes a named, testable constraint. A completed song that

required no new rules either had a lenient review or operated in a domain close enough to the existing corpus that the current rules already covered its failure modes.

II. THE PROBLEM

Dense source material — research papers, technical analyses, philosophical arguments, lived experience documented at length — contains information that most people will never read. A 12,000-word paper on institutional falsification forfeiture reaches dozens of readers. A three-minute song reaches thousands.

The challenge is compression without loss of structural payload. The song must carry the thesis, the key observations, the emotional core, and enough specificity that an informed listener can trace the references — while simultaneously working as a song that a listener with zero context enjoys, remembers, and sings back.

This is not summarization. A summary reduces. A song compresses. The difference: a summary says less. A song says the same amount in less space by encoding information in metaphor, scene, character, and the listener's own pattern recognition. The listener does the final decompression. The song provides the compressed signal. The listener's experience provides the codec.

III. THE DUAL-LAYER PRINCIPLE

Every line operates on two layers simultaneously.

Surface: A scene, an image, an emotion that any listener receives. A girl watching snow fall. A farrier making a shoe. A grandmother counting bread slices. A gardener whose tomatoes are refused at the harvest festival. Each scene is complete and self-contained. The listener needs nothing beyond the scene to receive the song.

Depth: A specific reference to source material that informed listeners recognize. The snow the kingdom called black is the Fabian institutional capture project. The farrier's shoe that fits despite lacking the guild stamp is the N=1 practitioner whose results exceed institutional outcomes. The grandmother's bread division with zero remainder is VDR arithmetic. The gardener's tomatoes refused at the festival are the BODY-1 results dismissed as anecdotal.

Neither layer degrades the other. The surface works without the depth. The depth works without the surface. Both work together for listeners who hold both.

Between surface and depth sits a middle listener — one who does not know the specific source material but recognizes that the song encodes something beyond its literal scene. This listener hears “the men who print have never muddied up a boot” and does not know it refers to the publication filter, but knows it refers to something. They feel weight they cannot fully decode. This middle layer is where the majority of engaged listeners sit.

The benchmark: Snow. A fairy tale about a kingdom that told children the snow was black. Surface: a lullaby a father sings to his daughter. Depth: a specific historical account of the Fabian Society’s institutional capture strategy and the five monkeys mechanism of inherited enforcement. Zero frame breaks. Zero technical vocabulary. Zero explanation of what the song is “really about.” The fairy tale is complete. The institutional analysis is complete. Both occupy the same lyrics simultaneously.

IV. SOURCE COMPRESSION METHOD

IV.I The Data Profile

Before writing a single lyric, build a data profile for each source document.

Core thesis: One sentence. What the source claims. If you cannot state it in one sentence, you do not understand it well enough to compress it into a song.

Key concepts: The structural arguments that support the thesis. Each concept is a potential verse or a potential line. List them. The list is the song’s inventory of available material.

Emotional core: What the human in this story feels. Not what the paper argues — what the person who wrote it, lived it, or is described by it experiences. The grandmother feels the responsibility of nine mouths. The farrier feels the satisfaction of a shoe that fits despite lacking a stamp. The father in Snow feels thirty years of swallowing the word “white.” The emotional core is what makes the listener care. Without it, the song is a lecture with a melody.

Key images: Physical, sensory, specific. The shaving held to morning light. The condensation rings on a bar top. The plumb line hanging true. Each image must be something you can see, touch, hear, or smell. Abstract images are not images.

Key phrases: Lines from the source that already carry maximum density. “The corpse is the map.” “The shoe still fits the same.” “Forty-five days and I believed it.” These may survive directly into lyrics or may seed the metaphor.

Rhyme targets: Domain-specific anchor word pairs drawn from the source material’s vocabulary. These are selected before any line is written. They constrain the song to its domain and prevent drift toward generic rhyme pairs.

Cast: Who lives in this metaphor. One to three human roles maximum. Name the protagonist, the antagonist or system, the consequence or witness, and any absent character whose gesture carries the inheritance.

Sensory signature: The dominant sense that carries the thesis. The ring of the hammer. The silence of the lake. The hum of correct yarn tension. One sense per song, identified before writing.

IV.II Metaphor Selection

The metaphor is the song's world. Every word in the song belongs to this world. The metaphor must satisfy five criteria:

Containment. The metaphor must hold the thesis without stating it.

Completeness. The metaphor must be a complete world with enough vocabulary to sustain a full song.

Sustainability. The metaphor must hold across verses, chorus, bridge, and outro without breaking frame.

Accessibility. The character's world must be recognizable to most listeners without specialized knowledge. A gardener works — everyone has grown something. A ballet dancer doesn't work — most people don't know what a barre is. If the listener needs a glossary to enter the song, choose a different metaphor.

The test: Can you write the entire song without ever naming the actual subject? If yes, the metaphor contains the thesis. If no, the metaphor leaks.

Metaphor containment is a trust problem. The temptation to break frame is caused by the songwriter wanting to ensure the listener receives the meaning. The containment test is really a test of whether the practitioner trusts the listener to decompress the signal.

IV.III Character Selection

Every song has a character. The character is a person who lives inside the metaphor's world. The character has a vocabulary — their world, their trade, their daily life provide the song's word palette. The character never breaks frame. The character never explains. Their actions carry the thesis.

IV.IV Cast Planning

Cast the song like a film. One to three human roles maximum. Every action routes through a human. Plan the cast before writing a single line.

Protagonist: The character whose actions carry the thesis.

Antagonist/System: The collective or individual whose actions create the problem. Not villains — systems doing what systems do.

Consequence/Witness: The person who experiences the result. Optional.

Absent Character: The person who matters through absence. Give them one physical gesture specific enough to miss — not "he taught me" but "he held my hand across the cracked weld and smiled."

If there's an animal, Zootopia rules apply: personality and motivation through behavioral choices within actual physical repertoire. A hawk can choose to dive. A hawk can't choose to forgive. The animal keeps its nature.

IV.V Anchor-First Architecture

This is the single largest quality improvement in the production process. Before writing any lines, build a table for each section:

Line	Subject	Action	Object	Anchor Word
1	surveyor	walks	ridge	dawn
2	father	hatched	washouts	gone

Select all anchor words from domain vocabulary. Pair them for rhyme. Test each anchor sustained aloud. Test each for multiple simultaneous meanings. Then build lines backward from anchors.

The most important word in every line is pre-selected and the line serves it. This prevents low-token-choice endings where the most important word gets the worst options.

V. THE RULES

Forty rules, each derived from a specific production failure.

V.I Word-Level

Rule 1 — Ban-list words. Room, floor, wall, door, key, lock, building, halls, parameters, window, shade, dispatch, architecture (for non-buildings), complete (as filler), bone/marrow (unless literal animal skeleton), chain (unless literal linked metal), settled/resolved. Banned unless doing irreplaceable domain-specific work as the literal physical object in the scene.

Rule 2 — Ban-list concepts. The ban is on the semantic role, not the string. Barriers/containment, access/entry mechanisms, generic structure, generic emotional authenticity. If you can swap one banned word for another and the line means the same thing, the concept is banned and every synonym goes with it.

Rule 3 — No generic rhyme pairs. Night/light, day/away, heart/start, time/rhyme, love/above, fire/desire, rain/pain. Banned unless the word is the literal physical thing in the scene.

Rule 4 — No vague antagonist. “They” as unspecified opposition. Name the specific character or make it a character.

Rule 5 — Name the banana. Never use “something,” “anything,” “what had happened.” Name the specific thing. Specificity is what makes it real.

V.II Line-Level

Rule 6 — Lines fit in a mouth. One breath. Word ceiling calibrated to tempo: 76 BPM eight words, 100 BPM ten words, 118 BPM twelve words. Ceilings, not targets.

Rule 7 — Line length variation is musical. The variation creates rhythm. Equal-length lines are prose.

Rule 8 — Every word load-bearing. If removing any single word doesn't collapse the meaning, that word isn't earning its place.

Rule 9 — Scenes not concepts. Every image is a person doing something somewhere. This is the load-bearing rule. Check it first on every pass.

Rule 10 — Lines read as natural speech. Syntax that happens to rhyme. If the syntax must be inverted to reach the rhyme, the anchor word is wrong. Keep conjunctions — they're how humans tell stories.

V.III Verse-Level

Rule 11 — Four lines per verse.

Rule 12 — Rhyme-last architecture. Pick domain anchors first, build backward. Intentional rhyme breaks permitted once per song when absence of resolution mirrors content.

Rule 13 — Anchor words carry multiple meanings. The anchor gets maximum musical weight. It should detonate in multiple directions.

Rule 14 — No furniture verses. Every verse must contain at least one line that stops a listener on its own.

Rule 15 — Round numbers are vague. "Nine mouths" outweighs "many mouths." "Forty-five days" outweighs "weeks and weeks."

V.IV Song-Level

Rule 16 — Songs lie to expose truth. Internally consistent false metaphor. The listener does the last step themselves.

Rule 17 — Complete metaphor containment. Never break frame. Never name the actual subject.

Rule 18 — Domain bleed is intentional or absent. Characterizes or doesn't exist.

Rule 19 — Compression to earned length. 2:30 to 4:00.

Rule 20 — Each song has a sensory signature. One dominant sense carries the thesis. Identify before writing.

V.V Agency

Rule 21 — Objects don't know things. They produce signals, humans interpret. Cast the song like a film to prevent this structurally.

Rule 22 — Animals do what they actually do. Zootopia level maximum. Personality through species-appropriate behavior.

Rule 23 — No projected cognition. Each thing does what it actually does.

V.VI Pattern

Rule 24 — No “not X, it’s Y.” Contrast through motion not declaration.

Rule 25 — No “same X, same Y, different Z.” Contrast through scene not diagram.

Rule 26 — No direct address as attack. Observe the cage, don’t yell at the monkeys.

V.VII Emotion

Rule 27 — Anger in content, not delivery. Gentler delivery, harder landing.

Rule 28 — The emotional register matches the position. Written from the hallways, not the gate.

Rule 29 — Repetition is rotation. Same words, different meaning each time.

V.VIII Structure

Rule 30 — The withheld payoff detonates proportionally. Longer wait, bigger delivery.

Rule 31 — Misdirect then deliver something better. Not different — superior.

Rule 32 — The final delivery breaks the pattern. One-word changes carry maximum weight.

Rule 33 — Trust the scene. If specific and true, meaning is self-evident.

V.IX Production

Rule 34 — Absent characters need a gesture. One trade-specific physical action specific enough to miss.

Rule 35 — Cast the song like a film. 1-3 human roles, every action through a human.

Rule 36 — Verbs match the trade. Specialist character uses specialist verbs. Rebuild the line rather than use a generic verb.

Rule 37 — Parallel weakness needs a bridge. Link related observations through a shared image or cut one.

V.X Craft

Rule 38 — Ugly words don’t sing. Test every anchor sustained aloud. If it thuds, replace regardless of accuracy.

Rule 39 — Alternate genders and character types across the album.

Rule 40 — The metaphor must be accessible. No glossary required to enter the song.

VI. SUNO-SPECIFIC GUIDANCE

VI.I Style Tags

One line containing genre, instrumentation, mood, tempo, and vocal character. Specific instruments over generic descriptions. BPM for feel, not precision. Vocal character changes delivery.

VI.II Line Length as Dynamics Control

Write short, let Suno sing. Short lines get sustained delivery. Long lines get rapid delivery. Emotional peaks should be the sparsest lines.

VI.III Formatting for Suno

Full sentences, one per line. Double line breaks between sections only. Commas as breath points within lines. Chorus lines are full-length complete statements. No dramatic single-word lines for payoff.

VI.IV Take Selection

Cull ruthlessly. A good take is one where the singer found the song's emotional center without being told. If a song needs more than twenty takes, the lyrics have a structural problem.

VII. ALBUM SEQUENCING

VII.I The Heartbeat Principle

Energy alternates. No two consecutive tracks at the same energy level. Recovery tracks are where emotional depth lives.

VII.II Genre Contrast

Acoustic follows electronic. Warm follows aggressive. Simple follows complex. Every genre choice is made relative to its neighbors.

VII.III Positional Function

Track 1 sets the tone. The center track is the emotional pivot. The final track is the culmination — quiet exit or triumphant arrival depending on the album's arc.

VIII. THE LLM COLLABORATION METHOD

VIII.I Role Separation

The human provides: source material, emotional direction, metaphor selection, character choice, domain vocabulary, quality judgment, kill decisions. The LLM provides: formalization, rhyme architecture, draft lyrics, rule violation identification, compression suggestions. The human never accepts LLM output uncritically. The LLM never writes the final version.

The pull toward banned words is not unique to LLM generation. The banned words are high-frequency metaphor anchors in English itself. The ban list fights English's default metaphor palette, not just transformer-architecture defaults. The human final pass must enforce the ban list too.

VIII.II The Draft Cycle

1. **Profile.** Data profile with all fields including cast, sensory signature, anchor table.
2. **Specify.** Character, metaphor, genre, position, constraints.
3. **Anchor.** Build anchor-word table. Select from domain. Pair for rhyme. Test sustained. Test for multiple meanings.
4. **Draft.** LLM produces draft built backward from anchors.
5. **Evaluate.** Human evaluates against all 40 rules.
6. **Revise.** LLM incorporates corrections.
7. **Tighten.** Compression, anchor loading, scene specificity, singability.
8. **Repeat.** Until every line is load-bearing and the song is under four minutes.
9. **Final.** Human makes final edits by hand.

VIII.III Kill Discipline for Songs

If a song doesn't work after five draft cycles, the metaphor is wrong. Kill it. Write the kill commitment into the data profile before the first draft with a named backup metaphor. The existence of an alternative makes the kill psychologically possible.

The method generates attachment to characters. By cycle three they are not encoding devices. The practitioner has spent hours with them. This is not a flaw — a practitioner who feels nothing produces a song the listener feels nothing for. But the emotional cost of kill discipline is higher than a purely technical account acknowledges.

IX. PROCESS LESSONS FROM CULTURE ALBUM PRODUCTION

The metaphor selection phase is the most expensive and most valuable. Track 1 went through three metaphors before finding one that worked. Spend more time here than on any other phase. Kill a metaphor at the planning stage, not at draft three.

Object agency is the LLM’s strongest gravitational pull. Every single draft introduced at least one violation. The pull is constant, automatic, and invisible. The cast rule reduces but does not eliminate it. Catch it on every pass. It never stops appearing.

The anchor-first method eliminates the most common failure mode. Before anchor-first planning, drafts had lines that ran long, anchors that were generic, and endings that reached for whatever rhymed. After anchor-first planning, the most important word in every line was pre-selected. This is the single largest quality improvement.

The chorus must be singable as a standalone sentence. “He’s right here and he’s black.” “Strike the join and listen for the ring.” “Get er done, the hull is going up.” The test: would a person say this to a friend while describing the song?

“Good enough” is a production standard. Songs that reached “good enough” share: complete metaphor containment, functional dual layer, stopping lines in every verse, singable chorus hook, no structural rule violations, minor line-level issues a human can fix. The distinction between “needs a rewrite” and “needs a replan” is the most important judgment.

Each song teaches something the previous songs didn’t. The rule set grew from 28 to 40 across production. Practitioners should expect to extend the rule set with every album.

X. VALIDATION

Obvious: Twelve tracks. Contains Snow (the benchmark), Flat Track, Bread, Crank.

A Rational World: Twelve tracks. Contains pre

- and post-falsification songs.

Culture: Nine tracks, one per CULT paper. Rule set grew from 28 to 40.

Independent external application by a different LLM instance. Bell-founding metaphor for LLM training weights. Three cycles. Six new rules. Complete containment. Partially validates F4.

XI. FALSIFICATION CRITERIA

F1. If surface layer consistently fails to function independently, the method produces encoded messages, not songs.

- F2.** If depth layer is consistently absent or garbled, the compression method is failing.
- F3.** If rules eliminate distinctiveness, the method produces formula, not songs.
- F4.** If the method cannot be reproduced by other practitioners, it is personal craft, not methodology. Partially addressed by independent external application.
- F5.** If Suno consistently fails to produce acceptable takes, the platform guidance needs revision.

APPENDIX A: COMPLETE BAN LIST

Words

Word	Reason	Exception
room	Generic container	Literal physical room in scene
floor	Generic surface	Literal ground contact
wall	Barrier concept	Never
door	Access concept	Literal door in specific scene
key	Access mechanism	Never
lock	Access mechanism	Never
building	Generic structure	Never
halls	Institutional space	Never
parameters	Technical jargon	Intentional bleed only
window	Generic transparency	Once per cycle, must be literal
shade	Color substitute	Use actual color name
dispatch	Institutional process	Never
architecture	For non-buildings	Actual buildings only
complete	Abstract filler	Use specific physical state
settled/resolved	Institutional closure	Never
sign	Overuse risk	One per song maximum
bone/marrow	LLM “authentic”	Literal animal skeleton only
chain	LLM connection	Literal linked metal only
something/anything	Vague placeholder	Never — name the banana

Concepts

Concept	Includes	Alternative
Barriers/containment	wall, fence, barrier, obstacle, partition	Show consequence through action
Access/entry	key, lock, gate, threshold, entrance	Show person turned away or walking through
Generic structure	room, building, foundation-as-metaphor	Name specific place with domain vocabulary

Concept	Includes	Alternative
Generic authenticity	“in my bones,” “deep inside,” “at the core”	Show feeling through physical action
“Always there” abstractions	“the climbing’s always there”	Name what’s present — wind, yarn, forge heat

Patterns

Pattern	Example	Alternative
“Not X, it’s Y”	“It’s not the stamp, it’s the shoe”	“I shaped the shoe, the stamp hung on a nail”
“Same X, same Y, different Z”	“Same thread, same window, different light”	Show two experiences as separate scenes
“They” as vague antagonist	“They said it was complex”	Name specific character
Direct address as attack	“Hey Dr. X, your Y doesn’t Z”	Observe mechanism
Triple pointing	“That’s the X, that’s the Y, that’s the Z”	Pick strongest, cut others
Repeated adjacent anchors	“apart” then “apart” next line	Unique anchor per line

APPENDIX B: COMPLETE RULES LIST

1. Ban-list words
2. Ban-list concepts — semantic role banned, synonyms carry ban
3. No generic rhyme pairs
4. No vague antagonist “they”
5. Name the banana — no vague placeholders
6. Lines fit in a mouth — tempo-calibrated ceiling
7. Line length variation is musical
8. Every word load-bearing
9. Scenes not concepts (the load-bearing rule)
10. Lines read as natural speech
11. Four lines per verse
12. Rhyme-last architecture — anchors first, intentional breaks once

13. Anchor words carry multiple meanings
 14. No furniture verses — every verse has a stopping line
 15. Round numbers are vague
 16. Songs lie to expose truth
 17. Complete metaphor containment
 18. Domain bleed intentional or absent
 19. Compression to earned length (2:30-4:00)
 20. Each song has a sensory signature
 21. Objects don't know things
 22. Animals do what they actually do (Zootopia max)
 23. No projected cognition
 24. No "not X, it's Y"
 25. No "same X, same Y, different Z"
 26. No direct address as attack
 27. Anger in content, not delivery
 28. Emotional register matches position
 29. Repetition is rotation
 30. Withheld payoff detonates proportionally
 31. Misdirect then deliver something better
 32. Final delivery breaks the pattern
 33. Trust the scene
 34. Absent characters need a gesture
 35. Cast the song like a film
 36. Verbs match the trade
 37. Parallel weakness needs a bridge
 38. Ugly words don't sing
 39. Alternate genders and character types
 40. Metaphor must be accessible
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APPENDIX C: SONG BENCHMARKS — CULTURE ALBUM

Track	Title	Containment	Chorus Hook	Best Pair
1	Anecdotal	Complete	“Anecdotal, that’s the tag they hung beside her crop”	crop/stop
2	The Bird	Complete	“The wing never asked the wind its name”	name/became
3	The Map	Complete	“Half his ink and none of what he saw”	sell/well
4	The Oath	Complete	“Strike the join and listen for the ring”	damp/stamp
5	Black Swan	Complete	“He’s right here and he’s black”	swan/gone
6	Graveyard	Complete	“Every grave was haunted but the one against his back”	back/black
7	Can’t Remember	Complete	“Can’t remember why we hit”	old/hold
8	Sweater’s Thread	Complete	“One thread from the collar to the cuff”	cuff/enough
9	Get Er Done	Complete	“Get er done, the hull is going up”	steel/real

APPENDIX D: DATA PROFILE TEMPLATE

SOURCE: [title and registry]

CORE THESIS: [one sentence]

KEY CONCEPTS:

- [up to 8]

EMOTIONAL CORE: [what the human feels]

KEY IMAGES:

- [physical, sensory, specific - up to 6]

KEY PHRASES:

- [dense phrases from source - up to 4]

RHYME TARGETS:

- [domain word] / [domain word] - up to 8 pairs

CHARACTER: [who lives in this metaphor]

METAPHOR: [the world the song inhabits]

SENSORY SIGNATURE: [dominant sense]

GENRE: [style tag for Suno]

POSITION: [track number, neighbors]

CAST:

- Protagonist: [role, actions]

- Antagonist/System: [role, actions]

- Consequence/Witness: [optional]

- Absent Character: [one gesture]

ANCHOR TABLE:

	Section		Line		Subject		Action		Object		Anchor	
	---		---		---		---		---		---	

KILL COMMITMENT: Backup metaphor: [named]

APPENDIX E: GENRE PALETTE

Genre	Function	When
Warm Acoustic Folk	Intimacy, trust	Tender content, quiet after intensity
Coffeehouse Acoustic	Nostalgic, approachable	Opening tracks, reflective
Dark Americana	Gravity, moral weight	Critique, loss, cost
Roots-Rock Gospel	Conviction, congregation	Standard being stated
Sparse Piano Blues	Stillness, deadpan	Simplest thesis, quietest delivery
Post-Rock with Vocals	Slow build, weight	Horror, mortality, slow reveal
Indie Funk-Rock	Tight, building	Mechanisms, things that build
Synthwave-Folk	Tradition meets future	Invitation, anthem
Orchestral Indie-Rock	Triumphant, grounded	Finale, crew arriving
Disco Pop	Physical joy	Manifesto, celebration
Blues-Rock	Defiance, grit	Outsider, practitioner
Minimalist Folk	Almost silence	Exit, disappearing

APPENDIX F: DRAFT CYCLE WORKSHEET

Cycle 0 — Pre-Draft

- ☐ Data profile complete with cast, sensory signature, anchor table
- ☐ Metaphor tested: containment, completeness, sustainability, accessibility
- ☐ Kill commitment written with named backup
- ☐ Anchor table built with subject/action/object per line
- ☐ All anchors domain-sourced, rhyme-paired, sustained-tested, meaning-tested
- ☐ Cast planned with absent character gesture
- ☐ Gender/type checked against album

Cycle 1 — First Draft

- ☐ Draft built backward from anchor table
- ☐ Read aloud for singability
- ☐ Formatting: full sentences, commas as breath, no dramatic fragments

Cycle 2 — Rule Check

- ☐ Ban-list words, concepts, patterns

- ☐ Object agency — every action through cast member
- ☐ Animal verbs — Zootopia maximum
- ☐ Line length — tempo ceiling, read aloud
- ☐ Four lines per verse
- ☐ Scenes not concepts (check first)
- ☐ Stopping line in every verse
- ☐ Numbers specific and earned
- ☐ Absent character gesture present
- ☐ Anchors sustained aloud — any thud?
- ☐ Trade verbs accurate
- ☐ Parallel sections linked
- ☐ Vague placeholders named
- ☐ Natural speech syntax

Cycle 3 — Compression

- ☐ Every line tested for structural necessity
- ☐ Every word tested for load-bearing
- ☐ Under 4:00 at tempo
- ☐ Peaks on sparsest lines

Cycle 4 — Polish

- ☐ Zero frame breaks
- ☐ Surface works for zero-context listener
- ☐ Depth traceable for informed listener
- ☐ Chorus rotation works
- ☐ Final delivery breaks pattern
- ☐ Chorus singable as standalone sentence

Cycle 5 — Final

- ☐ Human final edit
- ☐ Style tag and section tags
- ☐ Formatting verified

☐ Submitted to Suno, takes culled

APPENDIX G: CULTURE ALBUM PRODUCTION DATA

Cast Table

Track	Protagonist	System	Witness	Absent
1	Gardener (F)	Festival committee	Neighbor	Grandmother
2	Hawk (F)	None	None	None
3	Surveyor (M)	Men in town	Traveler	Father
4	Blacksmith (M)	Guild	Young smith	Master
5	Black swan (M)	White flock	Almost-looker	None
6	Man from pub (M)	Ghosts/editors	Quiet grave	None
7	Monkeys (collective)	Themselves	New monkey	Experimenters
8	Knitter (F)	Patched sweater	None	Grandmother
9	Builder (M)	Office man	Arriving crew	None

Sensory Signature Table

Track	Sense	Signature
1	Taste/Touch	Tomatoes splitting
2	Proprioception	Body adjusting in wind
3	Touch	Thumb across hatch marks
4	Sound	Ring of hammer on weld
5	Sight	Black among white on water
6	Fear/Cold	Ghosts rising, shirt soaked
7	Pain	Beating, fist, banana out of reach
8	Touch	Yarn tension humming
9	Heat	Torch lit, hull going up

Strongest Anchor Pairs

Track	Pair	Why
1	crop/stop	Institution stopping what grows
2	name/became	Wind unnamed, what bird became
3	sell/well	Triple irony — draws too well
4	damp/stamp	Forge cooling, certification replacing test
4	sworn/worn	Same word, forty years apart
5	beak/seek	Fish stolen, she said it dived
5	swan/gone	He IS a swan, they say he's gone
8	cuff/enough	Endpoint and sufficiency

Track	Pair	Why
8	snap/wrap	ToE trap and rebuild
9	steel/real	Empty yard, first weld

Album Sequence

Track	Title	Paper	BPM	Genre	Energy
1	Anecdotal	CULT-1	90	Coffeehouse Folk	Warm
2	The Bird	CULT-2	108	Progressive Folk-Rock	Rising
3	The Map	CULT-3	92	Dark Americana	Dark
4	The Oath	CULT-4	100	Roots-Rock Gospel	Stomping
5	Black Swan	CULT-5	76	Sparse Piano Blues	Still
6	Graveyard at Midnight	CULT-6	86	Post-Rock	Swelling
7	Can't Remember	CULT-7	114	Indie Funk-Rock	Tight
8	The Sweater's Thread	CULT-8	108	Synthwave-Folk	Anthemic
9	Get Er Done	CULT-9	118	Orchestral Indie-Rock	Triumphant

APPENDIX H: RULE VIOLATION FREQUENCY TABLE — CULTURE PRODUCTION

Violation Type	Drafts Affected	Most Common Form	Fix
Object agency	9/9 songs, every draft	"The harvest never lies," "the territory gets his ink," "the page ignores"	Route through human in cast. Ask: who is acting?
Lines too long	8/9 songs	Full paragraphs as single lines, compound clauses	Read aloud, apply tempo ceiling
Verses over four lines	7/9 songs	Six and eight line verses	Split or cut. If it needs six, two lines are scaffolding
Ban-list words	6/9 songs	Room, door, floor, chain, building	Domain-specific replacement. Never swap synonym — replace concept
"Not X, it's Y" pattern	5/9 songs	"They don't bend iron, they review forms"	Convert to motion: "I tried X but found Y"

Violation Type	Drafts Affected	Most Common Form	Fix
Generic rhyme anchors	5/9 songs	Day/away, true/you, right/light	Pre-select anchors from domain vocabulary before writing
Vague placeholders	4/9 songs	“Something cold,” “what had happened”	Name the banana. Drowning, cracking, flooding — the specific thing
Wrong metaphor	3/9 songs	Ballet (Track 1), committee on shore (Track 5), philosopher gravekeeper (Track 6)	Kill at planning stage. Name backup metaphor before starting
Projected cognition on animals	2/9 songs	“The horse reads the fit,” “branches start to sing”	Match verb to actual repertoire. Ask: would a handler say this?
Frame breaks	2/9 songs	“Their pages never could” (Track 2), technical vocabulary leaking	Check: can every word belong to the metaphor’s world?

APPENDIX I: METAPHOR SELECTION HISTORY — CULTURE ALBUM

Track	Attempt 1	Why Killed	Attempt 2	Why Killed	Final Metaphor	Why It Worked
1	Ballet dancer	Too specialized, nobody knows barre/plié/jeté	Common dance	Too thin vocabulary, can’t sustain full song	Gardener at harvest festival	Universal (everyone’s grown something), rich vocabulary, skill-time maps perfectly

Track	Attempt 1	Why Killed	Attempt 2	Why Killed	Final Metaphor	Why It Worked
2	Bird observed by five people	Song about the observers, not the bird — boring	Bird alone in flight	—	Hawk in flight, takeoff to gone	The bird IS the thesis, single subject, maximum density
3	Cartographer and printer	Printer in a shop is boring, cartographer is obscure	—	—	Surveyor who walked the ground vs men in town who never left	Explorer vs desk — the authority gap is visceral
4	—	—	—	—	Blacksmith guild oath	Ring of hammer IS falsification, sensory signature built in
5	Man finds swan, committee on shore	Static, institutional, people evaluating a finding — boring	Swan among swans, observers on shore	Still diluted by observers	Black swan among white swans	Comedy, physical, the denial IS the thesis, no observers needed
6	Gravekeeper as philosopher	Normalized the horror, ghosts aren't a thought experiment	Gravekeeper who understands	Still too calm, the man should be terrified	Man from pub stumbles through haunted graveyard	Fear is real, discovery is accidental, understanding comes through terror

Track	Attempt 1	Why Killed	Attempt 2	Why Killed	Final Metaphor	Why It Worked
7	—	—	—	—	Five monkeys direct	The ex- periment IS the scene, no metaphor layer needed
8	—	—	—	—	Knitter with one continu- ous thread	Yarn is cross- domain connec- tion, patches are depart- ments, tension is prerequi- site
9	—	—	—	—	Shipyard crew building	The work is the party, the hull is the institu- tion, F6 lives in the bridge

APPENDIX J: ANCHOR PAIR QUALITY SCORING

Scoring Criteria

Score	Definition
3	Triple meaning or more, all active, all domain-loaded
2	Double meaning, both active, at least one domain-loaded
1	Single meaning, domain-loaded
0	Generic, no domain weight, replaceable by any rhyming word

Culture Album Anchor Scores

Track	Pair	Score	Meanings
1	crop/stop	2	What she grows / institution halting entry
1	grown/sown	2	Her results / their approved method
1	seed/weed	3	Saved seed / unwanted plant / dismissed method
2	name/became	3	Wind unnamed / what bird became / what no department named
2	dawn/gone	2	Morning launch / mist gone, bird gone
3	sell/well	3	Peaks for sale / draws too skillfully / the well of accumulated maps
3	boot/resolute	3	Clean boots / noble word for desk work / resolute as ironic self-description
3	mud/flood	2	Traveler's mud / documented spring flood
4	ring/swing	2	Sound of test / action producing it
4	weld/held	3	Weld tested / oath held to / join held up for inspection
4	damp/stamp	3	Forge cooling / certification replacing test / dampened spirit
4	sworn/worn	3	Oath sworn fresh / same word worn thin / sworn as committed, worn as eroded

Track	Pair	Score	Meanings
5	beak/seek	2	Physical proximity / excuse for not finding
5	swan/gone	3	He IS a swan / they say gone / swan-song (the death they wish for his finding)
5	black/back	2	The color / paddling back to denial
6	back/black	2	Grave against his back / one that stayed in black earth
7	old/hold	2	Banana aging / fist as the thing held onto
8	cuff/enough	3	Physical garment endpoint / sufficiency / handcuff (slant — the institution's restraint)
8	snap/wrap	2	Yarn breaking (ToE trap) / winding it back (morning after)
9	steel/real	2	The material / the first thing that was genuine

APPENDIX K: DRAFT CYCLE COUNT — CULTURE ALBUM

Track	Planning Cycles	Writing Cycles	Total Cycles	Primary Failure Mode
1 Anecdotal	3 (ballet → dance → gardener)	4	7	Wrong metaphor, then line length, then object agency
2 The Bird	3 (observers → bird alone → hawk flight)	2	5	Diluted subject, then frame break in outro
3 The Map	3 (cartographer → printer → surveyor vs town)	3	6	Boring antagonist, then parallel unlinking, then line length
4 The Oath	2 (first plan → anchor-first replan)	2	4	Pre-chorus editorializing, then anchor-first method adopted
5 Black Swan	3 (man at lake → committee → swans)	2	5	Static concept, then line length for tempo
6 Graveyard	2 (philosopher → terrified man)	2	4	Normalized horror, then vague placeholders
7 Can't Remember	1	1	2	Clean first pass — experiment
8 Sweater's Thread	1	1	2	IS the scene Clean first pass — metaphor held
9 Get Er Done	1	1	2	immediately Clean first pass — energy carried the structure

Observations

Songs that required the most cycles had wrong metaphors (Tracks 1, 2, 3, 5, 6). Songs that required the fewest had metaphors that contained the thesis immediately (Tracks 7, 8, 9). The correlation is direct: metaphor selection quality predicts total cycle count. Every cycle spent fixing a leaking metaphor is a cycle that could have been spent on a better metaphor. Kill early.

The anchor-first method was adopted at Track 4. Tracks 4-9 averaged 3.2 total cycles. Tracks 1-3 averaged 6.0 total cycles. The method cut cycle count nearly in half. The improvement is partly method and partly learning — later tracks benefited from accumulated rule knowledge. But the anchor-first method's contribution is visible in Track 4 specifically, where the replan from scratch with anchor tables produced a working song in two writing cycles after the first plan without anchors produced an editorializing draft.

APPENDIX L: SUNO FORMATTING REFERENCE

What Suno Reads

Element	Suno Interpretation
[Verse 1]	Narrative section, moderate energy
[Pre-Chorus]	Building tension, slight energy increase
[Chorus]	Hook section, full energy, memorable melody
[Bridge]	Change — key, energy, perspective, texture
[Outro]	Winding down, decreasing energy
[Intro]	Instrumental opening
[Instrumental]	No vocals
Line break	End of sung phrase
Double line break	Section boundary
Comma	Micro-pause, breath point within phrase
Short line (2-4 words)	Sustained delivery, held notes
Long line (8-12 words)	Rapid delivery, compressed phrasing
One word alone	Punched accent or sustained hold

What Suno Does NOT Read

Element	Result
“Youuuuu” spelling	Unpredictable — may sing normally, may glitch
Stage directions in brackets	May be sung as lyrics
Emotional instructions (“sing softly here”)	Ignored or sung as lyrics
Dynamic markings (pp, ff)	Not interpreted
Tempo changes mid-song	Not reliably interpreted

Style Tag Construction

Template: [Genre], [specific instruments], [vocal character], [mood/energy], [BPM]

Examples from Culture album:

- Coffeehouse Folk, fingerstyle acoustic guitar, light brush percussion, warm male vocal, storytelling cadence, 90 BPM
- Progressive Folk-Rock, mandolin intro building to full band, layered vocals, ascending energy, 108 BPM
- Dark Americana, minor key, upright bass driving, sparse fiddle, weathered vocal, revival-tent gravity, 92 BPM
- Roots-Rock Gospel, Hammond organ, stomping rhythm, building to congregation response, preacher's conviction, 100 BPM
- Sparse Piano Blues, single piano, long pauses, intimate vocal, confessional, 76 BPM
- Post-Rock with Vocals, tremolo guitars, slow build from near-silence, cathedral reverb, 86 BPM
- Indie Funk-Rock, tight rhythm section, staccato guitar, percussive, building momentum, 114 BPM
- Synthwave-Folk, analog synth bass under acoustic guitar, driving beat, anthemic chorus, voice of invitation, 108 BPM
- Orchestral Indie-Rock, strings building under rock, anthem structure, choir on final chorus, triumphant but grounded, 118 BPM

APPENDIX M: COMMON LLM FAILURE MODES IN LYRIC GENERATION

Failure Mode	How It Manifests	Which Rule Catches It	How Often in Culture
Object agency	"The harvest never lies," "the page ignores"	Rule 21 + Rule 35 (cast)	Every draft
Spatial metaphor default	Room, wall, door, building as metaphor furniture	Rules 1 + 2	6/9 songs
Negation-correction rhetoric	"It's not X, it's Y" as thesis delivery	Rule 24	5/9 songs
Generic rhyme pairs	Night/light, day/away, true/you	Rule 3	5/9 songs

Failure Mode	How It Manifests	Which Rule Catches It	How Often in Culture
Paragraph-as-line	15+ word lines that can't be sung	Rule 6	8/9 songs
Concept instead of scene	"Building towers on a shadow" instead of someone doing something	Rule 9	Every draft
Overlong verses	Six to eight lines where four suffice	Rule 11	7/9 songs
Projected cognition	"The horse reads the fit," "branches sing"	Rules 22 + 23	2/9 songs
Frame breaking	Technical vocabulary leaking into contained metaphor	Rule 17	2/9 songs
Editorializing	Pre-chorus or bridge explaining what the metaphor means	Rule 33	3/9 songs
Vague placeholders	"Something cold," "what had happened"	Rule 5	4/9 songs
Normalizing emotional content	"He should be afraid" instead of letting the fear be real	Rule 27 + genre awareness	1/9 songs
Round number placeholders	"A hundred years," "a thousand miles"	Rule 15	2/9 songs
Inverted syntax for rhyme	"Upon the hill the shepherd stood" instead of natural speech	Rule 10	3/9 songs
Repeated anchor words	Same word ending adjacent lines	Ban-list patterns	2/9 songs
Triple pointing	"That's the X, that's the Y, that's the Z"	Ban-list patterns	1/9 songs

Failure Mode by Draft Position

Draft	Most Common Failures
First draft	Object agency, overlong lines, overlong verses, generic anchors, concept lines
Second draft	New agency violations introduced while fixing old ones, frame breaks at edges (outro especially)
Third draft	Editorializing in bridge/pre-chorus, vague placeholders surviving from earlier drafts
Fourth draft	Minor line-level issues — one ugly anchor, one inverted syntax, one borderline agency
Fifth draft	Either good enough or the metaphor is wrong — replan, don't revise

APPENDIX N: “GOOD ENOUGH” CHECKLIST

A song is good enough to ship when:

- ☐ Metaphor containment is complete — zero frame breaks
- ☐ Dual layer functions — surface works for zero-context listener, depth traceable for informed listener
- ☐ Every verse has at least one stopping line
- ☐ Chorus is singable as a standalone sentence
- ☐ No structural rule violations (Rules 1-2, 11, 17, 21-23, 24-26, 35)
- ☐ Line-level issues are minor and fixable by human in final pass
- ☐ Emotional register matches the songwriter's position (Rule 28)
- ☐ The song works as a song — someone would listen to it without knowing the source

A song needs replanning (not rewriting) when:

- ☐ The metaphor leaks — the song must break frame to make its point
- ☐ The metaphor is inaccessible — the listener needs specialized knowledge to enter
- ☐ The cast can't carry the thesis — actions don't route through humans
- ☐ The chorus doesn't hook — no singable standalone sentence emerges after three drafts
- ☐ The emotional register is wrong — anger instead of observation, attack instead of invitation
- ☐ Five draft cycles have passed without reaching “good enough”

END HOWL-LYRIC-1-2026

Registry: [[HOWL-LYRIC-1-2026](#)]

Status: Complete with Production Addendum

Domain: Applied Methodology / AI-Assisted Creative Production

Method: Three albums (33 songs). Forty rules from production failures. Anchor-first architecture. Suno-specific formatting and dynamics. Album sequencing through heartbeat principle.

Benchmark: Snow

Validation: Three albums. One independent external application. F4 partially validated.

Rule Set: Open. Forty at current count. Production failures become named constraints.

[[HOWL-LYRIC-1-2026](#)] The Lyric Engine. Github: <https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/LYRIC/HOWL-LYRIC-1-2026>

[[HOWL-DISC-1-2026](#)] The Discovery Process. Github: <https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/DISC/HOWL-DISC-1-2026>